

Tobacco Institute Airs 'Other Side'

By DALE CURRY

To the smoker, yesterday's visit to New Orleans by officials of The Tobacco Institute was like a ray of hope in an otherwise dismal picture of information surrounding the addictive habit.

Visiting with media in New Orleans and other cities, the officials are trying to dispel reports that smoking causes cancer when, in fact, they say, no solid proof has yet been offered.

In doing so, they offered some hope to smokers caught in the habit, while admitting there is no proof, either, that smoking does not cause cancer.

"WE WANT to show you the other side of this controversy," said Horace R. Kornegay, president of The Tobacco Institute, meeting with newsmen at the Monteleone Hotel.

For more than half an hour, tobacco officials presided over an elaborate presentation of film and speeches, quoting statistics and refuting charges that left even some nonsmokers attending wondering where that left the Surgeon General and the American Cancer Society (ACS) sitting.

Basically, their argument is this:

—that the government and ACS are basing their warnings on what might be coincidence,

—that, in doing so, money being spent to prove that cigarettes are guilty may divert funds from finding the real cause of cancer.

—that scientific studies used as basis for warnings by the government have not been made available for scrutiny of other scientists,

—that the most recent major ACS findings that cigarette smoking caused cancer in 12 dogs is false.

Kornegay said the research involving 86 dogs with a dozen contracting cancer caused the ACS to call for a review of cigarette companies' advertising policies.

Meanwhile, Kornegay said, cigarette companies called for scientific information on the experiment but none was provided. Eventually, he added, the number of dogs with cancer "mysteriously shrunk to two."

Kornegay said the tobacco industry has two main aims in dealing with public attitude toward smoking. One is to foster research for which the industry awarded a \$2 million grant this year; the other, to make clear its position — "not that our product is above scientific suspicion, not that it has been scientifically exonerated, but simply that it is in every sense still on trial."

DR. MARVIN A. Kastenhbaum, statistical director of The Tobacco Institute, said, "The overwhelming majority of smokers never develop lung cancer."

He said most so-called unequivocal evidence linking cigarette smoking to a multitude of diseases is based upon inference drawn from statistical data.

"It has been widely accepted that if certain diseases are statistically more common among cigarette smokers than non-smokers, we can assume a cause and effect relationship," he stated. "There are many ways to demonstrate that this is scientifically unsound."

FOR EXAMPLE, he said, it was once thought that corn caused the disease known as pellagra because certain population groups that subsisted on corn had an unusually high incidence of the disease.

"Then it was discovered that pellagra was caused by a deficiency of niacin in the vitamin B complex," he said. "So now we know the cause of pellagra is not what people eat — it's what they don't eat."

He said it also is unexplainable why six men to one woman have lung cancer and why the disease is twice as prevalent in the British as in Americans when the smoking habits are similar.

In sum, institute officials called for a picture "not so one-sided" in the controversy and further examination of the facts.

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